suspicion of treason.

Briefly, this is the sorry tale: soon after Akbar's Rajput commander Man Singh's men had repelled Mirza Hakim's troops from Punjab and killed his star swordsman, Shadman, Man Singh sent word that he had found a letter from Hakim's secretary to Shah Mansur in Shadman's bags. Such letters were a common trick – they were meant to fall into the wrong hands and create disharmony and suspicion in the enemy ranks. Therefore, Akbar dismissed the news. Soon after, however, an old servant of Hakim's arrived in Akbar's camp and made a beeline for Shah Mansur, choosing him as his intermediary to the emperor. At this dubious coincidence, Akbar had his accountant arrested. A few days later, the chief of his camp police came to Akbar with another set of letters detailing a plot by which Shah Mansur's troops – stationed in Punjab – were to join Hakim's army. Now, writes Abul Fazl, Akbar's 'wrath . . . blazed forth'.

Akbar's anger was no joke. His usual expression was 'tranquil, serene and open', writes Monserrate, but 'when he is angry, [full] of awful majesty'. Once, on this very trip, when a man took a shortcut in obeying Akbar's orders, the emperor had him tied to an inflated leather tube and flung into the Indus, to be 'carried hither and thither in the middle of the river at the mercy of the current'. The poor man was taken out and eventually pardoned – Akbar was 'easily excited to anger, but soon cools down', as the Father noted. Until he did, however, the emperor's fury was not easily faced; and it is no wonder that when Akbar, enraged, accused him of treason, Shah Mansur 'blathered in reply'.[28]

Whatever excuses the accountant stammered out, they did him no good. Shah Mansur was 'hung . . . on a tree'.[29]

No one mourned his passing.

Of the legions of men who fill the annals of his reign, Akbar's accountants are the most unpopular. Perhaps this is a good indication of how rigorously Akbar enforced his revenue reforms, but it was bad luck for the officials involved. Of his three best-known money managers, only Todar Mal died a natural death. Muzaffar Khan was tortured and killed by the Bengal rebels; Shah Mansur was hanged – and, here too, Akbar's amirs may not have been entirely innocent of his death.[30]

According to Abul Fazl, there was 'great rejoicing in the camp' when Shah